Dilli-Nama: A Historical Memoir

Glimpses of a life, lived amongst many Delhis



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Between Two Delhis

I grew up close to the banks of the Yamuna, in a part of Delhi that belongs to an odd interval in the city's long life: older than the New Delhi of India Gate and Connaught Place, yet younger than the *Purani Dilli* of the Mughals.

I remember that Delhi mostly from the backseat of my father's WagonR. We would drive through Civil Lines and the North Campus of Delhi University, through roads lined with old trees and government offices.

This part of the city was built right after 1911, when the British decided to shift the capital from Calcutta, and for two decades before Lutyens' Delhi was ready, this was the country's administrative capital.

I fondly remember the bus ride to my school, sometimes half-asleep in my seat, sometimes peeking out of the window. We would first pass the Old Secretariat on the left, which to me looked like an imposing white palace. It had once functioned as the Parliament of the country, where men such as Motilal Nehru and Madan Mohan Malaviya once sat, and where Muhammad Ali Jinnah unsuccessfully argued against the Rowlatt Act, while Gandhi watched from the visitor's gallery.



Left: Old Secretariat, now the Vidhan Sabha of Delhi; Right: Ambedkar Memorial

A little further, turning my neck to the right, I could see the place where B.R. Ambedkar spent his final days and died, where now stands a memorial in his honour. Then came my school itself, next to the Chief Minister's residence and close to Ludlow Castle, which had once been the residence of the East India Company's representative to the Mughal court. I didn't know any of this during those school days. I was more concerned about not being late and completing my homework.

Sometimes, we would go for morning walks in the Northern Ridge. It lay right next to my home, a stretch of forest and parkland through which we passed so routinely that it barely seemed worth noticing. But it was here that the fiercest fighting took place during the Revolt of 1857. Hundreds of British soldiers died on this ridge. John Nicholson, the commander who led the British, is buried just in front of my school in the cemetery that still carries his name. Local legend says his ghost still haunts it, and that on certain nights you can see headless British soldiers on horseback moving through the graves.



The Flagstaff Tower inside the Northern Ridge — Where British families sought refuge during the Revolt of 1857

The landscape I knew as green and peaceful had once been a landscape of fear, artillery and blood. Today the Ridge is where the residents jog in the mornings, where students and couples from the university come to sit in the evenings — unaware, mostly, that they're standing on the exact ground where the first war for India's independence was fought and lost.

It was much later — years after I had stopped taking that bus — that I understood that I had been passing through the remnants of many older

Delhis. The city I knew as mine was only the latest layer, built over the many Delhis that had come before it.

The City Between Us

The Pleasure Garden

Take the Yellow Line from Vishwavidyalaya, my home station, towards Millennium City Centre, and alight three stations later at Kashmere Gate — the largest metro station of Delhi, serving one of the most densely populated parts of the city. From the upper concourse, look beyond the traffic, and you will see the statue of Maharana Pratap rising from a large green park.

That park is Qudsia Bagh.

It is an enormous public park lying at the northern edge of *Purani Dilli*, pressed between the old Mughal city and Civil Lines. It was here that I used to meet Yashodhara almost every morning. She came by rickshaw from the nearby Kashmere Gate, while I would take the Metro or sometimes a cycle. We would walk through the park talking about the ordinary affairs of our lives, what our parents had said the other day, our studies, and the latest gossip about our friends and families.

Sometimes we played badminton, sometimes climbed onto the children's swings and sometimes exercised in the small open-air gym for amusement. And when we grew tired, we would sit on the steps of a pavilion in one of the gardens. She would sit in my lap, and we would remain there for hours, sometimes talking, sometimes saying nothing at all, listening to the birds and watching the beautiful peacocks of the bagh.



The pavilion where Yashodhara and I spent many hours together

The pavilion and the Bagh in which we spent those hours had been there long before us. Qudsia Bagh was built in 1748 for Qudsia Begum, one of the most powerful women of the late Mughal period. In those days it stood beside the Yamuna as a vast pleasure garden, enclosed by high walls and containing a palace, waterworks, gardens, pavilions and a mosque. The Mughal Empire was in decline already and the garden was amongst the last great architectural feats of Mughal Delhi's fading splendour.

Then came the Revolt of 1857, when the Bagh was caught up in the fighting around Kashmere Gate and the British positions to the north. The palace was destroyed in the battle, much of the garden's enclosing walls disappeared and what remains of the grand pleasure garden are some ruins of a gateway, the mosque, and a pavilion which was later modified by the British. In a sheltered enclosure of this very pavilion, a young couple would share some intimate moments 150 years later.

Decades after the revolt, on a morning in the summer of 1929, a group of revolutionaries of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA) gathered in the Bagh. They shared a meal and before saying farewell, one of the women revolutionaries pricked her finger and applied a blood *tilak* on the heads of Bhagat Singh and Batukeshwar Dutt. That day, the two famously bombed the Central Legislative Assembly.

The garden had witnessed the decline of the Mughal Empire, the gatherings of revolutionaries and the passing of generations. But by the time we knew it, the great pleasure garden had been reduced to a public park. There were children playing football, old men exercising and doing yoga in the morning and the rich from the Civil Lines coming for morning walks in their Jaguars.

The Lake

Now let's go further south along the Yellow Line into the heart of South Delhi, where lie medieval Delhis older than even the *Purani Dilli* of Shah Jahan.

Next to IIT Delhi and the posh neighbourhood of Green Park is Hauz Khas, known for its coaching centres, cafes, bars and the young crowd looking for somewhere to spend an evening. Within it is the Hauz Khas Park, or Deer Park.

I first came here as a child, on a school picnic. Our school always took us to the Lodhi Garden for every picnic, so I was rather pleased when they finally decided that Delhi contained other places as well. I saw deer for the first time in my life that day, and was awed by the enormous lake in the centre of the park.



The Hauz Khas Lake

It was later that I discovered that the lake was not a natural lake, but a man-made reservoir. Alauddin Khilji, the fourteenth-century Sultan of Delhi, had it built to supply water to Siri, the fortified capital he was building nearby. Siri is almost entirely gone now and the Siri Fort Sports Complex stands on its site. The reservoir itself, part of the infrastructure of a capital that has disappeared, remains.

A few decades after the Khiljis had fallen, Firoz Shah Tughluq had a madrassa and a mosque constructed on the southern edge of the lake, in what is now called the Hauz Khas Fort Complex. The old monuments still look towards the same water, but almost everything else around them has changed. The madrassa is no longer a centre of learning, and today these seven hundred year old monuments sit oddly beside the

cafes and bars where young Delhi comes in evenings to enjoy the view of a lake whose original purpose they are unaware of.

Firoz Shah chose to be buried beside his madrassa where his dilapidated tomb now stands overlooking the lake.

Years after that childhood picnic, I returned to this tomb with Yashodhara. She had been there on the picnic too, somewhere among the same crowd of children, though neither of us knew the other then. Now we sat next to the tomb together, hand in hand, looking out over the lake.

Sultans and Saints

Ik Oankaar

Back on the Yellow Line, past Kashmere Gate, we come to Chandni Chowk — the heart of Delhi-6.

Jahanara Begum, Shah Jahan's eldest daughter, laid out the street nearly four centuries ago, when Delhi was at the zenith of its power. A canal once ran down its centre, reflecting moonlight so beautifully that the street took its name from it — Chandni Chowk, the moonlit square. The canal was paved over at the start of the last century and what's left is one of the busiest and loudest stretches of road in the city.

At one end of the street stands the Lahori Gate of the Red Fort, from whose ramparts Jawaharlal Nehru first raised the flag of an independent India in 1947 — a tradition every Prime Minister has continued ever since, from the same place from where Mughal emperors had once ruled over India.



The entrance to Chandni Chowk, with the Digambar Jain Lal Mandir and Gauri Shankar Mandir on the left

Walk into the street from this end and the first thing you encounter is the Digambar Jain Lal Mandir on your left, a deep-red Jain temple crowned by a tall and imposing *shikhara*. Directly beside it, in shades of yellow and orange, stands the Gauri Shankar Mandir.

And then the street takes over. Vendors, rickshaw-wallahs and shoppers, with shops lining both sides of the road and spilling their goods onto the pavements — sarees, lehengas, ready-made clothes, footwear, jewellery and all manner of small household goods. The adjoining *galis* have bazaars of their own — Dariba Kalan for silver and jewellery, Kinari Bazaar for zari, lace and wedding trimmings, Nai Sarak for books and stationery, and Khari Baoli for spices and dry fruits. A little further on the right is a McDonald's, which has always struck me as oddly out of place among *galis* selling some of the best food in Delhi — chhole bhature, jalebis, chaat, dahi bhalle, bedmi poori with aloo sabzi — enough to make anyone's mouth water.

Further still stands the Sunehri Masjid, built in the early eighteenth century. In 1739, when Nadir Shah invaded and plundered Delhi, he is said to have stood on its roof and given the signal for a *qatl-e-aam*.

Thousands were killed across Shahjahanabad, and Delhi is said to have run red with blood.

Right beside this Masjid, with its own grim history, a cream-and-red facade rises above the street with shining golden domes. This is Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib, the place in Delhi which is closest to my heart.

Around three and a half centuries ago, a delegation of Kashmiri Pandits, under pressure to convert to Islam from the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb, came to the ninth Sikh Guru — Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib, seeking his help and protection. The Guru's eight-year-old son, Gobind Rai, who would grow up to become Guru Gobind Singh, suggested that the Kashmiri Pandits tell the authorities that they would convert only if his father, Guru Tegh Bahadur, converted first. This would turn their persecution into a direct confrontation between the Mughal state and the Guru.

Guru Tegh Bahadur agreed to stand in their place. He was arrested and brought to Delhi in 1675 and was given an ultimatum: convert or die. When he refused to convert, his disciples were executed in front of him — Bhai Mati Das was sawn in half, Bhai Dayal Das was boiled alive and Bhai Sati Das was wrapped in cotton and set on fire. The Guru still did not relent. He was then beheaded publicly on this very street.

A small shrine now marks the place where his disciples were executed. Directly opposite it, at the place where the Guru himself was martyred, stands Sis Ganj.



Gurudwara Sis Ganj Sahib

What Guru Tegh Bahadur did is usually described as the ultimate sacrifice for the principle of religious freedom, which it certainly was. But I am not sure if that is the best way to understand it. A person can sacrifice himself for a principle, however noble, and still remain within the boundaries of an idea to which he has attached himself. He belongs to an *-ism*: a defender of a position, a member of a camp, someone willing to die for what he believes to be right.

What Guru Sahib did was of a very different order. It was the manifestation of a love left with nowhere to be selective or limited, flowing from the realization of the Absolute Unity underlying everyone and everything — what Nanak called the *Ik Oankar*, Shankara called the

Brahman and the Sufis called *al-Haqq*. Such love begins when the self no longer sees itself as an isolated thing standing apart from the rest of existence.

This love is not quite like the love between me and Yashodhara, or even that between a parent and a child. Such relationships are entangled with a fear of loss, possessive attachment, dependency and a desire to hold on to what is loved. The love that flowed in Guru Sahib was of another kind. It begins when the impulse to possess and preserve begins to fall away. If there is ultimately no isolated self standing apart from everything else, then the suffering of another cannot remain external to me. What he did, then, was not a choice between his own life and the lives of others, but the only way of being possible for him — because their suffering was his own.

Whenever I come out of the Chandni Chowk Metro, past the *tehbazari* crowding the exit, Sis Ganj is the first thing I look for. I cover my head with a *rumal*, enter, and bow before the Guru Granth Sahib and before Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib, not merely to a man whose life I admire, but to the Divine that had found such a perfect expression in him.

I sit in the Darbar Sahib, listening to *shabads* from the Granth Sahib, and think of the Guru and of the things I hold on to so tightly — my ambitions, my attachments, my fears, the people and experiences I want to keep from changing.

Then I step outside again. The street is still there. The shops are still open. The same crowd is still moving through it. But beneath the shops and the crowd rushing past lie the many Chandni Chowks that came before this one — crowded, noisy streets inhabited by people who, like me, once had their own ambitions, attachments, fears and loved ones. They are all gone.

Beside the Beloved

From Chandni Chowk, continue on the Yellow Line to Central Secretariat and change to the Violet Line for JLN Stadium. I once stood here at the exit with Yashodhara beneath the shade of the station, waiting for the rain to stop before we could go to Humayun's Tomb.

Humayun, the second Mughal emperor, built his capital at Dinpanah on the banks of the Yamuna. What remains of it is preserved within the Purana Quila (Old Fort) Complex, near Pragati Maidan. He spent much of his reign fighting to keep an empire that kept slipping from him, and when stability finally arrived, he fell — comically, I must say — down the stairs of his library to his death. Tradition places the ancient Indraprastha of the Pandavas from the *Mahabharata* on this same ground. And if that's true, this would make it the oldest layer of Delhi.

After his death, Humayun was not buried at Dinpanah. His tomb stands further south, beside the *dargah* of Nizamuddin Auliya, a Sufi saint of the Chishti order.

To get to the *dargah*, one has to pass through a narrow *gali* thick with the smell of meat and other food being cooked, which honestly is not the most pleasant walk for a vegetarian like me. At the end of the *gali* is the entrance to the *dargah*.



The Dargah of Nizamuddin

Nizamuddin preached *ishq* — a love of God so complete that everything other than the Real, the Absolute beneath all transient things, gradually loses its hold over the heart. His most famous disciple was Amir Khusrow, whose grave lies only a few feet from his master's. Khusrow himself is almost a mythic figure in the cultural history of India: a poet and musician of extraordinary, almost unmatchable range.

He is regarded as the father of *qawwali*, and his qawwalis including *Dam Mast Qalander* and *Chhap Tilak* are still sung across the subcontinent. Khusrow was Nizamuddin's favourite disciple, deeply devoted to his master. When Nizamuddin died, Khusrow was devastated and died within months, buried beside him. Tradition says one visits Khusrow's grave before Nizamuddin's.

Nizamuddin kept a hard line between the spiritual and the political, which brought him into conflict with Sultan Ghiyasuddin Tughluq. When the Sultan, returning from a military campaign, warned him to leave

Delhi before his arrival, Nizamuddin is said to have replied, "*Dilli abhi door hai*" — Delhi is still far away. The Sultan was killed in the collapse of a pavilion on the outskirts of the city soon after. The phrase survives to this day, used as a warning against celebrating too soon.

Two centuries after Nizamuddin's death, Humayun was buried beside him, his widow deliberately choosing a site close to the saint's grave. The emperor who had spent his life saving an empire now lay a short distance from the man who had never possessed one.

Today, thousands come to the *dargah* of Nizamuddin Auliya and Amir Khusrow, laying *chaadars* on their *mazaars*. On Thursday nights, *qawwals* sing Khusrow's verses to his master. Across the city in the north, *langar* is served every day at Sis Ganj, and people still come to bow their heads before Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib, eat together and do *sewa*. Centuries after his execution, he remains part of the daily life of the street.

Ghiyasuddin Tughluq and Aurangzeb, however, are gone and forgotten, few now even know where their graves lie. Tughlaqabad lies in ruins, the Mughal court has disappeared from the Red Fort, and the Delhis they built have been swallowed up by the ones that came after them.

The Other Side of Home

Now let's return home, to the part of Delhi around Vishwavidyalaya and North Campus where I grew up. Some of my fondest memories are still on these roads — sitting in our WagonR as my parents drove us around the University, looking at the old college buildings, passing the crowded streets of Kamla Nagar, buying shoes and clothes in GTB Nagar or Camp as we always called it. They were part of the landscape of my early years, places I passed through so often that they became etched into my memory.

One thing I didn't know, for most of those years, was what the word "Camp" was short for.

In 1911, King George V camped near this ground for the Delhi Durbar. The road connecting his camp to Coronation Park was named Kingsway. The King left, but the name remained: Kingsway Camp.



GTB Nagar aka Camp

Then came 1947, when Partition brought one of the largest migrations in human history and Delhi received lakhs of people displaced from what had become Pakistan. Kingsway Camp was transformed into the largest refugee camp in Delhi, sheltering nearly three lakh people at its peak in tents and barracks, amongst which were both sides of Yashodhara's family — her father's from Lahore, her mother's from Multan.

The refugees gradually moved into permanent houses and newly developed colonies in the area, and the boundaries of the old camp

disappeared into the neighbourhood around it. In 1970 it was renamed Guru Tegh Bahadur Nagar — GTB Nagar. Delhi University, right next door, gradually reshaped the area. As the University grew and North Campus filled with students, the place changed with it. Rooms became PGs, coaching centres opened and cafes followed the coaching centres. A settlement built for refugees became, within two generations, one of the more expensive addresses in North Delhi.

We used to have family dinners here — at Samrat, run by a family of refugees, or sometimes at Sagar Ratna, right above the GTB Nagar metro station. My father would bring me here to buy books, and when I scored well in my exams, he would buy me a cricket bat, football boots or whatever piece of sports equipment I had set my heart on.

A few minutes away, on the other side of the University, is Kamla Nagar. This area began developing around the Ghanta Ghar — the Ram Swarup clock tower, built in 1941, modelled after the older, more famous one in Chandni Chowk that later collapsed. I've always thought of ours as Delhi's answer to the Big Ben. We bought my school uniform every year from here, and my father would bring us sweets from Manohar Bikaneri across the road.



Left: Ghanta Ghar, the Big Ben of Delhi; Right: Kamla Nagar

Kamla Nagar itself came later, in the 1950s, developed by DLF as a planned residential colony for well-off families. Being next door to the University did to Kamla Nagar what it had done to GTB Nagar — shops, cafes, and a permanent student crowd arrived, until it became something like DU's common room.

I remember wandering through its market, my hand in my mummy's, as she took me from one shop to another. She would spend what felt like an eternity deciding between sarees and suits, rejecting whatever the shopkeeper brought, asking to see something else, something better, while I sat annoyed on a stool in the corner, waiting for her to be done.

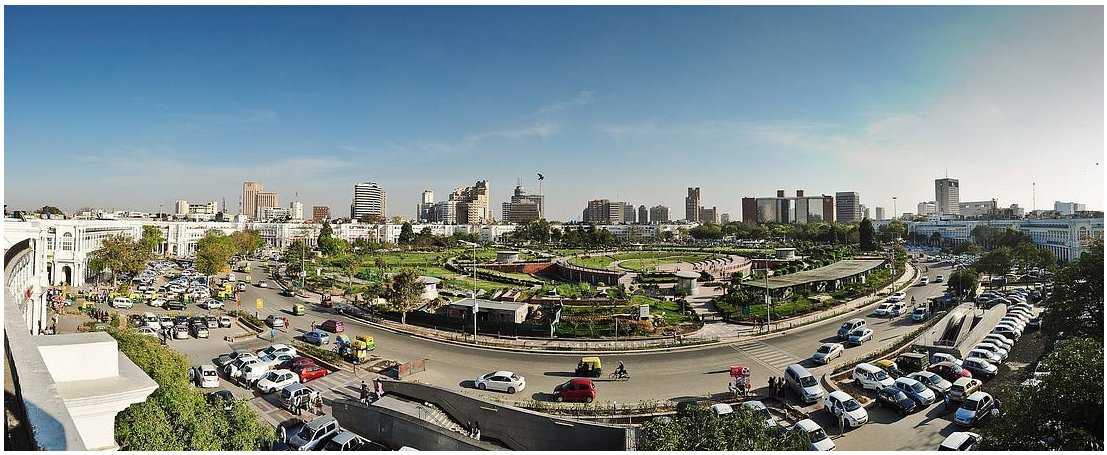
Years later, on the same streets, it was Yashodhara's hand instead of my mother's, and the same waiting — her turning in front of a mirror, asking what I thought, while I offered opinions she thought were useless. After our shopping, we went to McDonald's, where cheesy fries were non-negotiable, or to Vaishnav Chaat Bhandar, where my mother would buy chaat for the family and where Yashodhara and I would eat *golgappe* instead.

On other evenings I waited for her outside her coaching centre in GTB Nagar, after which we had spicy chowmein or momos from some *thela* as we walked the market, or just wandered past the *kothis* that line those streets now, the same streets where, not long before either of us existed, her family had queued for a single bucket of water a day. We talked about whatever her teachers had taught that day — one of whom she had decided was the worst she had ever had — as the evening went from gold to grey around us.

The Ladder

Let us go now to one of the busiest parts of New Delhi — Rajiv Chowk Metro Station, directly beneath Connaught Place or CP.

Step out of the station and you find the white colonial-era colonnades of CP, lined with showrooms, cafes, restaurants and offices, with people constantly moving through them. It was among these colonnades and blocks that I used to walk with Yashodhara, talking about whatever had happened that day — what one of our friends had said, what we were going to do that weekend or which film we had watched together the previous night on Discord. We would sit in the Central Park for a while and then go to the Indian Coffee House near the Pracheen Hanuman Mandir for a masala dosa, her favourite.



Skyline of Connaught Place: The Quintessential New Delhi

CP was where my family came too. My father would bring me to Wenger's, where we bought sweets and other confectioneries. On some evenings, my family and the families of my *maasis* would have dinner here in one of the restaurants, after which we would take a late-night drive around Lutyens' Delhi and stop for ice cream at the India Gate. Those evenings belonged to the Delhi of my childhood.

Then I left Delhi for college.

I returned home for Diwali in the middle of my first semester, after being away for three months, and for the first time I noticed the air differently. I could not see very far ahead or breathe properly outdoors. Pollution was hardly new to me, I had grown up with Delhi winters and was accustomed to it. But after a few months away, the extent of the deterioration suddenly became much more apparent.

The Sahibi — a tributary of the Yamuna — runs close to my home through GTB Nagar. It has been foul and polluted for as long as I can remember, so much so that the locals simply call it the "Naala" — a filthy drain. Its waters eventually reach the Yamuna. Standing in that smog, looking at the *Naala*, I felt for the first time that the modern Delhi — the youngest of all the city's layers — might not remain habitable for much longer. And if nothing changed fast, that day might not be very far away.

From Rajiv Chowk, the Yellow Line takes us north again, back to Kashmere Gate again. This is where Yashodhara and I would say our goodbyes after our outings. I would walk her to the exit, she would climb into a rickshaw, and as it pulled away she would turn back to wave, still smiling. I would follow the rickshaw a little way down the road, waving back, until it turned a corner and was gone.



Exit Gate 1 of the Kashmere Gate Metro Station — where Yashodhara and I would say our goodbyes

That is how I saw her last. I did not know it then.

Yashodhara is gone. So are my school friends, my school, my father's WagonR, and the boy who once sat in its backseat.

Everything with which we build our lives — our relationships, ambitions, wealth, achievements, reputation and power — is transitory. We want the transient to remain still long enough for us to call it ours. But the world does not remain still for us, and much of the sorrow of ordinary life comes from this contradiction.

Beneath the Delhi I knew were many older Delhis — cities built, inhabited, loved, fought over and eventually abandoned. The people who filled them had their own ambitions, their own attachments, their own fears and their own people to love. Their joys and sorrows were not abstractions, they were as immediate to themselves as I am to

myself now. Yet almost all that remains of them are ruins and fragments — and mostly, nothing at all.

To see this clearly is not to turn away from the world, but to change the way we live in it. The experiences we go through and the losses we suffer become the rungs of a ladder leading the mind beyond itself. One has to live in the phenomenal without mistaking it for the permanent, and experience what is now without demanding that it remain.

Delhi has been my ladder, teaching me through its own impermanence. It is a beautiful place, and I couldn't help falling in love with it. Getting attached to it, though, would be ironic. The city has spent my whole life showing me that nothing remains as we find it, least of all the things we love.

And that is why I am grateful to it — to the Delhi which has seen the Pandavas, the Sultans and Mughals, the British and independent India, to the Delhi in which I grew up. It has been a great teacher to me.

One day, the Delhi I know will pass into the layers of the city that come after it. And in time, so will I.

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